

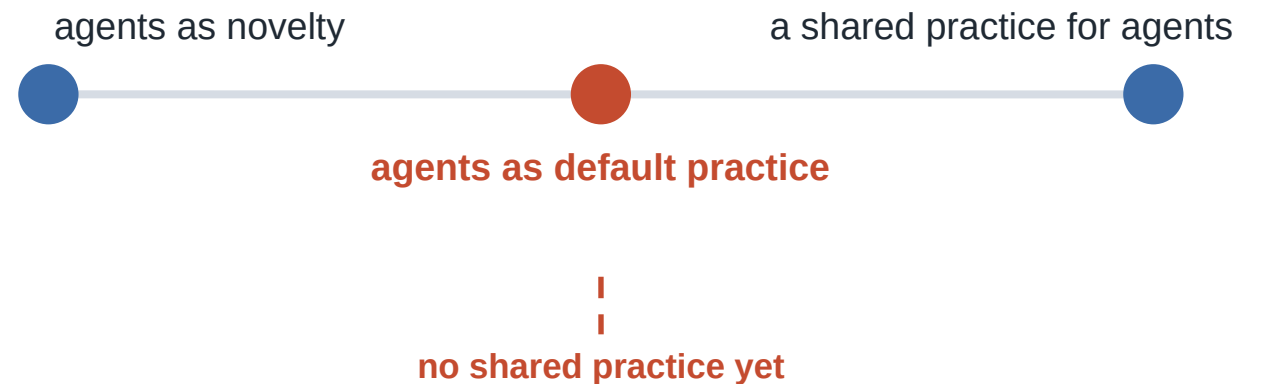
Document discipline catches agent drift before review

An evaluation briefing for engineering leaders whose teams build with AI agents



2 Agents now write most production code without a shared practice

- Most professional developers ship agent-written code every day
- The output is locally good and globally inconsistent
- The document disciplines human teams built never reached the agents
- Every practice era gets its equivalent of test-driven development



how agent-written code became the default before any discipline caught up

3 Without that practice, agent code drifts from specs and decisions

- Specs, designs, and tests fall out of sync because nobody walks them between sessions
- A feature ships whose design contradicts a decision recorded months earlier
- Each new conversation re-improvises the workflow, so reviews that should happen do not

1

Drift

specs and code
diverge between
sessions

2

Contradiction

a design ignores an
earlier decision

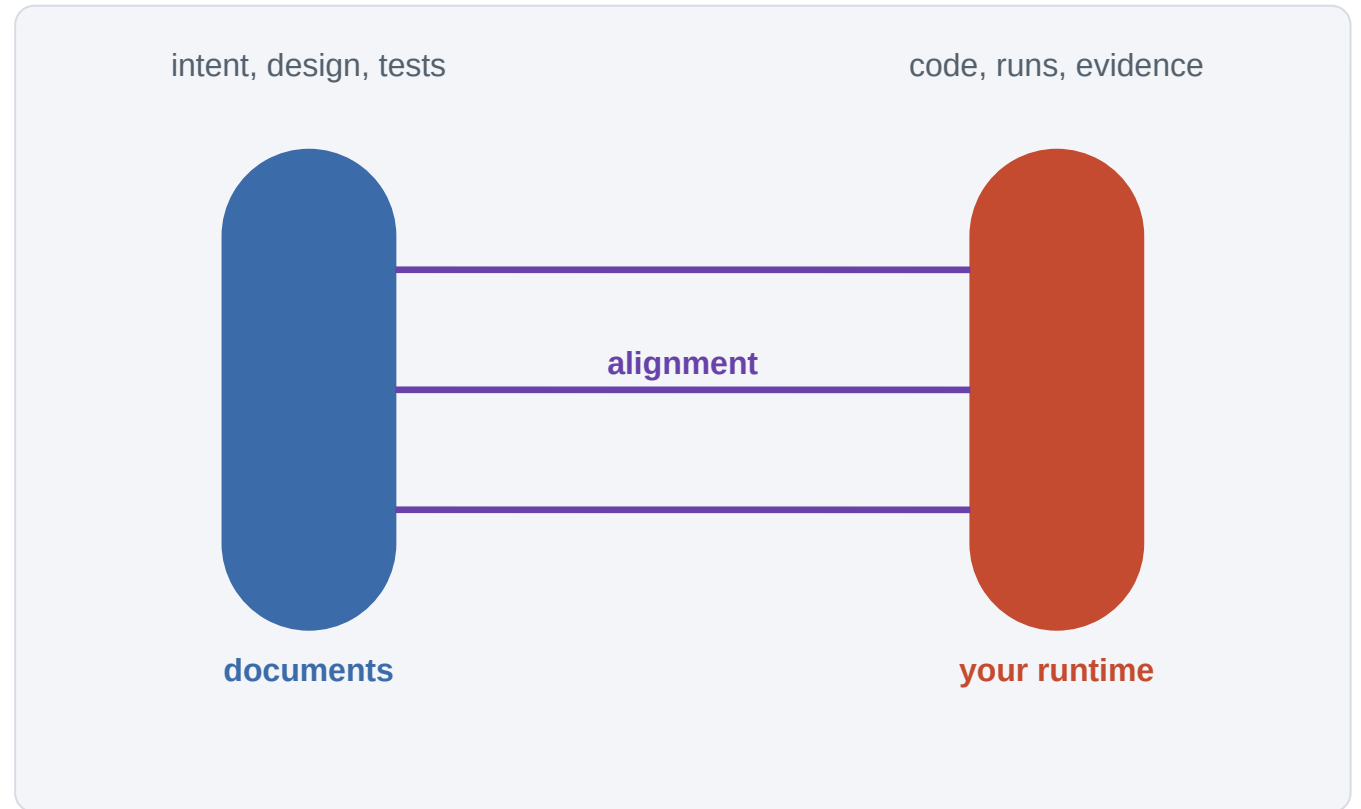
3

Lost context

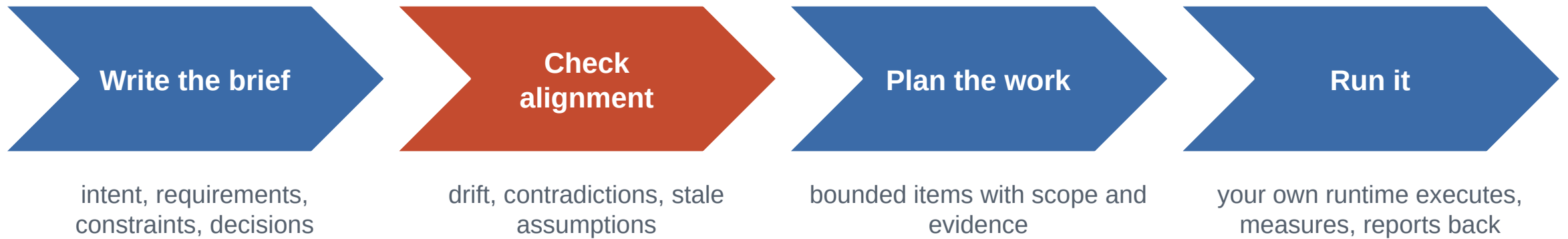
every session starts
from zero

4 HELIX traces every agent change to a governing document

- HELIX is a method, not a tool: document templates plus one alignment skill
- Every change traces to the document that governs it
- The content runs on any agent runtime that reads and writes markdown
- Teams adopt one document type at a time



5 The alignment check reads those documents before anyone codes



the step nobody does by hand today

6 Drift surfaces at the alignment check instead of in review

Today

Ad hoc prompting, manual document upkeep, and hoping for the best

Drift shows up in review or in production

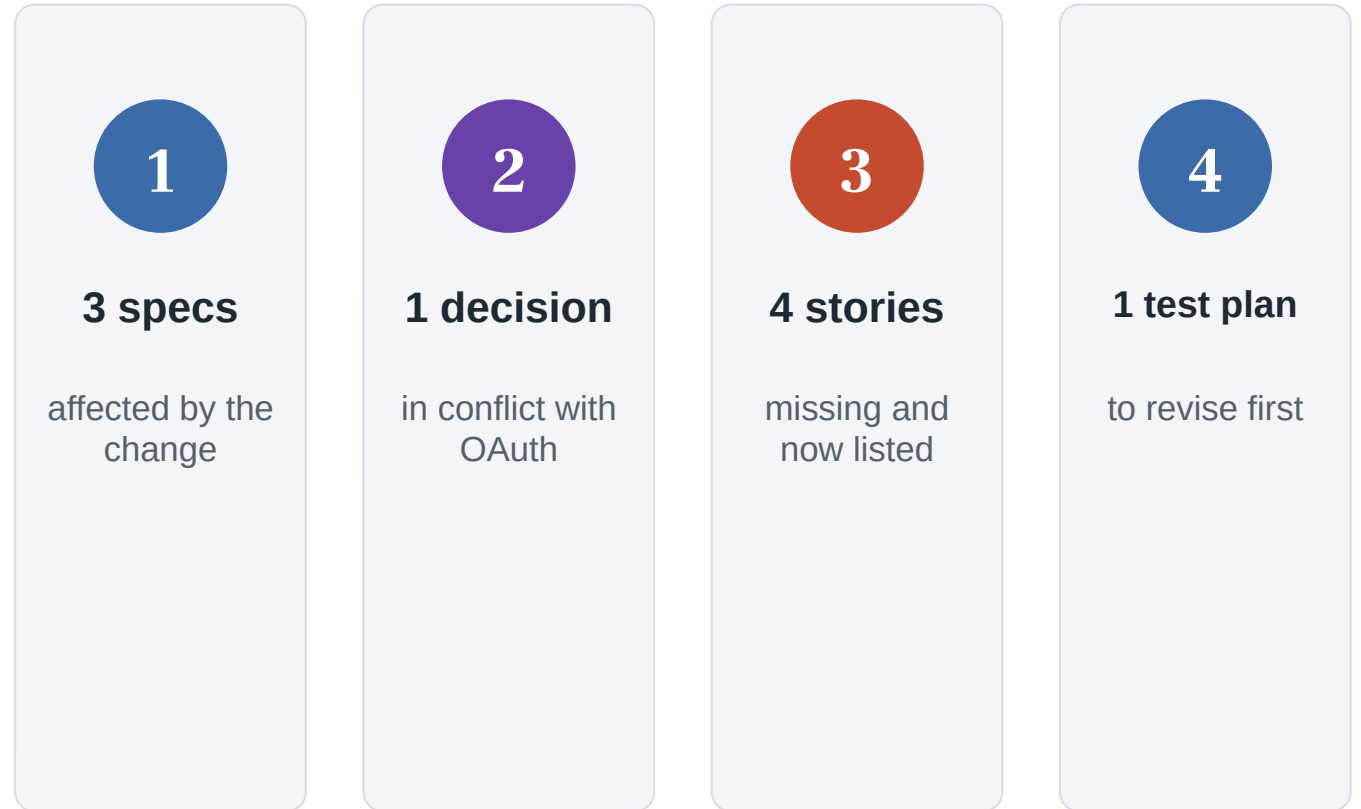
With HELIX

- ✓ Agents and people share one practice, and every change traces to a document
- ✓ The alignment check catches drift before the first line of code

Verdict: the biggest change is when drift is found

7 One OAuth change showed three drifted specs before coding

- A team asked its agent to add OAuth login
- The alignment check found 3 affected feature specs and 2 affected designs
- It flagged 1 recorded decision that conflicted with the OAuth pattern
- It listed 4 missing user stories and 1 test plan to revise



8 A healthy project averages under 3 drift findings per check

< 3

drift findings per check on a healthy project

TARGET

3

runtimes documented within 12 months

TARGET

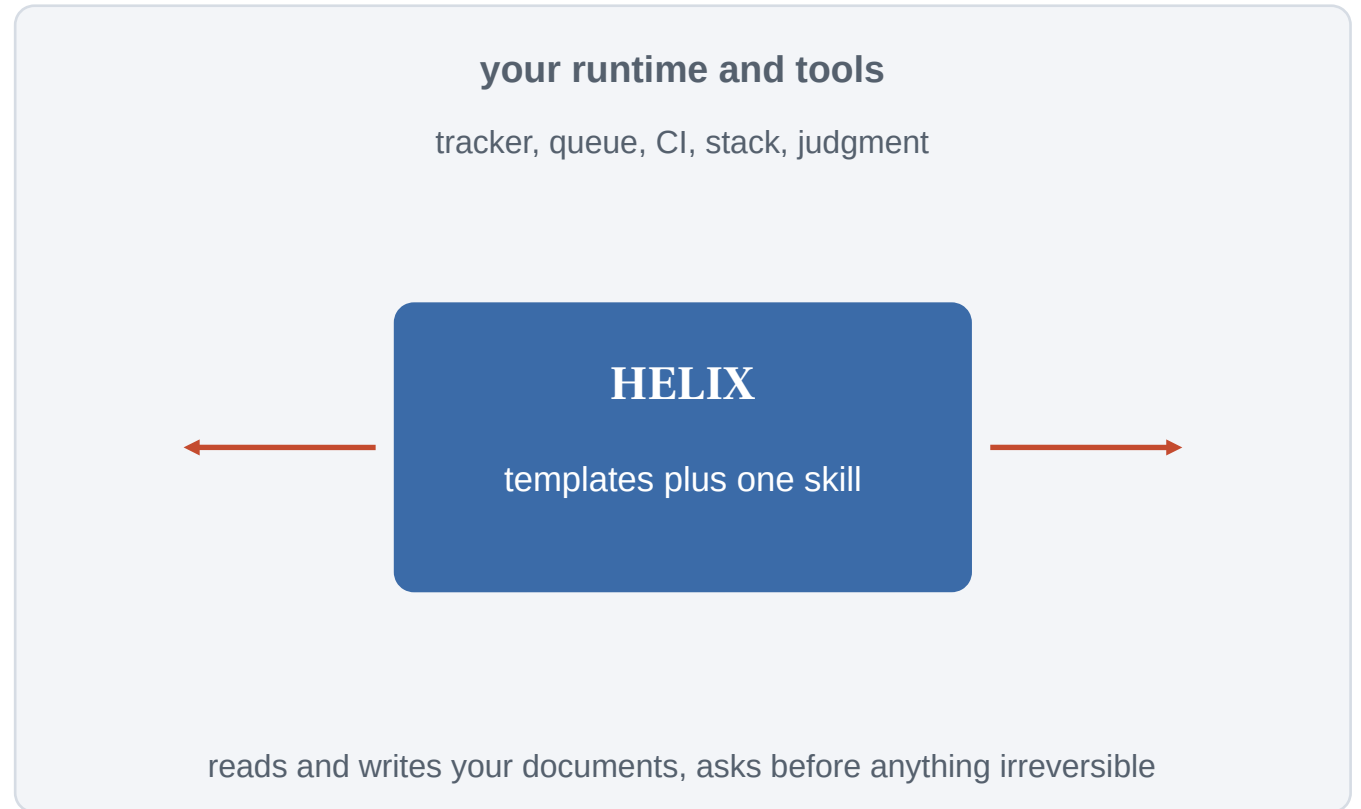
50+

public repositories within 18 months

TARGET

9 HELIX checks documents and leaves your runtime and stack alone

- No command-line tool, tracker, queue, or execution engine ships with it
- Your technology choices stay yours; HELIX imposes none
- Product, design, and architecture judgment stays with people
- How much an agent does without asking is a dial you set



10 Pilot HELIX on one project this quarter and count the drift

Pilot HELIX on one project this quarter and count the drift

	Step	Owner	Date
1	Pick one active project with an agent already in the loop, by the end of this week	_____	_____
2	Adopt the templates and run one alignment check on its documents in the first sprint	_____	_____
3	Review the findings together after four weeks and decide whether to widen	_____	_____

Without a trial the practice stays improvised and drift keeps surfacing in review

Sources

Id	Claim or figure	Governing artifact and section
S1	HELIX is a methodology and artifact catalog for AI-assisted teams; the double helix of a document strand and an execution runtime; document disciplines packaged as templates plus one skill	docs/helix/00-discover/product-vision.md#mission-statement
S2	AI-assisted development crossed from novelty to default; most professional developers ship AI-touched code daily; locally good, globally inconsistent; the era's TDD-equivalent practice	docs/helix/00-discover/product-vision.md#why-now
S3	Three failure modes: artifact drift, inconsistent agent behavior (a feature whose design contradicts an earlier ADR), lossy session boundaries	docs/helix/01-frame/prd.md#problem
S4	Positioning: a methodology you adopt, not a platform you join; runs on any runtime that reads and writes markdown; adopt incrementally	docs/helix/00-discover/product-vision.md#positioning, docs/helix/00-discover/product-vision.md#key-value-propositions
S5	Four-step workflow contract: write the brief, check alignment, create the work plan, run it in the factory	docs/helix/01-frame/prd.md#core-workflow-contract

Sources (continued)

Id	Claim or figure	Governing artifact and section
S6	Target market: current solution is ad hoc prompting, manual document maintenance, hoping for the best; teams switch because every change traces back to a governing artifact and the alignment skill catches drift early	docs/helix/00-discover/product-vision.md#target-market
S7	OAuth example: the alignment skill finds 3 feature specs and 2 solution designs affected, 1 ADR in conflict, 4 user stories to add, 1 test plan to revise, ordered by authority	docs/helix/00-discover/product-vision.md#user-experience
S8	Targets: healthy artifact sets average < 3 alignment findings per run; 3 documented runtime deployments within 12 months; 50+ public repos within 18 months	docs/helix/00-discover/product-vision.md#success-definition , docs/helix/01-frame/prd.md#success-metrics
S9	Non-goals: no CLI, tracker, queue, or execution engine; no technology choices imposed; no replacement for product, design, or architectural judgment; autonomy is a controllable spectrum	docs/helix/01-frame/prd.md#non-goals